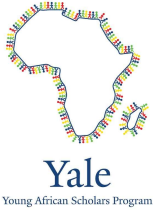


Guide to writing your U.S. university application essay

You likely will have to write one longer essay and a few short essays (1-2 paragraphs each) as part of your applications to U.S. universities. These essays serve a dual purpose: they demonstrate to the admission committee that you have strong written English skills, and they introduce you to the committee in your own “voice”, giving them a perspective on you as a person (rather than as a list of grades, activities, or accomplishments).

You must put effort into writing these essays, as they are one of the most important parts of an application. While very few students have academic grades or extracurricular activities that are exceptional, every applicant has a unique personality and story, and the application essay is a powerful tool for making your application memorable. Below we have provided some tips on writing your essays. It is important to remember that there is no set formula for an effective essay, and our biggest tip is to focus on writing an essay that is a true reflection of who you are.

- Address the essay question fully. Be sure your essay answers the question asked!
- Avoid vague statements such as “Because I love my country” or “Because I want to help people” or “Since a young child I have always wanted to...”. Instead, ensure that your essay provides details to help the reader visualize your specific circumstances, or to understand your unique way of seeing things.
- Avoid too much overlap with other sections of your application package. Do not treat every question or essay as an independent task, rather think about what is being portrayed by your whole application. Admissions officers only have your application to learn about you, so consider highlighting different aspects of your personality in different parts of the application.
- Aim to “connect the dots” between the activities/grades listed on your transcript, and who you are as a person. Don't just describe what you've done, but instead talk about what you gained from these experiences and how this will make you an ideal student. Your essays should **NOT** simply restate or list your accomplishments!
- You don't need to try to invent the most original topic, but your essay must be your original perspective or experience of that topic. Keep it genuine! Admission committees are hoping that each admitted student will bring something unique to the university's community. So even if you decide to write about an experience that many others have had, you can demonstrate through your essay what way the event had an impact on you and why that was important in molding who you are today. Even if application readers can recognize the universal value in activities such as volunteering, they want to read about your unique experiences and challenges while volunteering.



- Admissions officers want to use your application to get to know who you are, so use your own voice! It is important to make good use of grammar, vocabulary, and punctuation - and in doing so to demonstrate your knowledge of the English language - but try not fill your essay with complicated, lengthy words that you would never use in conversation.
- If needed, address any gaps or weaknesses in your application or academic performance. Turn them into a positive if you can. For example, if you were terribly ill during one term of school and got lower grades that term or year, note this in your application. (Perhaps not in the essay—there is an “additional information” section where you could explain this.) But if you’ve faced a longer-term challenge such as gaps in school due to lack of fees, or moving around a lot and changing schools frequently, the circumstances and what you learned from the experience might make for a good essay topic.
- Be likable. Universities see themselves as communities, where people have to get along in dormitories, classes, clubs and teams, etc. Are you someone they would like to have dinner with, hang out with, have in a discussion section? Think, "How can I communicate this about myself without just standing up and saying it?" You might decide to talk about a time when you disagreed with someone but worked with them to find common ground. Or about what you learned from a challenging team/group exercise. There surely are many examples of when you had to tackle a new sort of challenge, giving you the chance to show the readers how you tackled it and what you learned/how you’re different or better now.
- Be cautious with your use of humor. You never know how someone unfamiliar to you, or from a different culture is going to respond to you, especially if you offer something humorous. A good rule to follow is: “if you wouldn’t tell that joke to your grandmother, don’t tell it in your essay!”
- Keep in mind that the essay is a creative writing piece. But you should still follow the general good-essay format, ensuring that you have an introduction, supporting evidence for your statements, and a conclusion. And these all must relate to the overall theme of your essay, serving as connecting your points from beginning to middle and end.
- Pay attention to the word count! The limits provided are a maximum, but as general practice you should try to be near the maximum of the word limit or page limit. MORE words don’t make for a better essay! But too few words can send the message that you didn’t put much effort into the essays, which might mean you don’t care much about that application. Don’t send that signal!
- Be sure to have at least one person—someone with very good English skills who will give you honest feedback—to review your essay. It’s important to be sure that your essay ‘makes sense’ to others. You might also try reading your essay out loud to someone. If your listener gets confused or lost as you read, then you know there are problems in your essay that need to be corrected so that it reads clearly.
- Proofread, proofread, **PROOFREAD!** Simply typographical or grammatical errors will make a terrible impression on the admission committee and are easily avoided by proofreading again and again!